was preparing for a major showdown with the US Army in Korea. Despite China having announced its intention of annexing Tibet, the international community was caught completely unawares when the People's Liberation Army (PLA) boldly moved into Tibet on 7 October. When the Tibetan government turned desperately to India for help, Nehru seemed completely at sea. Appeals for aid were turned down and the Tibetans were advised by India to settle the matter peacefully, whatever that was supposed to mean. The fact of the matter was India had absolutely no clue as to how the situation should be handled.

The Chinese, with this move, had stood all previous policies on their head. They had brushed aside the British concept of Tibet functioning as a buffer state between China and India. 'Frankly, we were like headless chickens,' Major General D. K. Palit would say half a century later. 'Forget about the 90 per cent Indians who did not know where Tibet was, half the people in External Affairs could not pinpoint it on a map either.' Palit had been the commander of 7 Infantry Brigade and later Director, Military Operations during the 1962 conflict. 'To make matters worse, communists in India were celebrating the Chinese move while right-wingers were wanting military intervention with little or no idea what that actually meant on the ground.'

Brigadier John Dalvi further reinforces the point: 'India was in a quandary. The entry of Chinese troops in Tibet had potentially ominous long-term consequences. Tibet had been a buffer zone and had been vital to British India's strategic defence. The abrupt removal of this buffer would alter the geo-political balance, and henceforth India would have a live northern border to reckon with. There was a definite possibility that Tibet could be used as a springboard for aggression against India whenever it suited the communist regime in China.'

At the time of independence, India's official position was that it recognized Tibet as an independent country while also recognizing the fact that it was under Chinese suzerainty. After the annexation of Sinkiang in 1949, Delhi started getting alarmed. Overnight, India had a common border with China in Ladakh. As the communists tightened their hold over China, Chairman Mao declared that henceforth Tibet should be regarded as a part of China. By early 1950 the People's Republic of China (PRC) had made it amply clear that it intended to annex Tibet. In a meeting held in Kalimpong, West Bengal, between the Tibetans and the Chinese, General Yuan